CHAPTER 25 Indian Parliamentary Group

RATIONALE OF THE IPG

M.N. Kaul and S.L. Shakdher have nicely explained the rationale of the Indian Parliamentary Group (IPG) in the following way:

The establishment and development of relations among parliaments constitutes part of the regular activities of national parliaments. Although promotion of inter-parliamentary relations has for many years been a significant part of the work of parliamentarians, recently it has received a new thrust due to the increased inter-dependence of nations in a global environment. It is imperative that parliamentarians will join hands to safeguard democracy and work in synergy to confront the challenges before the world and convert them into opportunities to facilitate peace and prosperity in their countries as well as globally.[1]

Inter-parliamentary relations thus assume great importance today when the whole world is beset with many pressing problems. The problems that are faced by one parliament today may confront another tomorrow. It is, therefore, essential that a link should exist between various parliaments of the world. This link is maintained by India through the exchange of delegations, goodwill missions, correspondence, documents, etc. with foreign parliaments through the machinery of the IPG that acts both as the National Group of the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU) and also as the India Branch of the Commonwealth Parliamentary Association (CPA).[2]

COMPOSITION OF THE IPG

The IPG is an autonomous body. It was formed in the year 1949 in pursuance of a motion adopted by the Constituent Assembly (Legislative).[3]

The membership of IPG is open to all members of Parliament. The former members of Parliament can also become associate members of the IPG.[4] But, the associate members are entitled to limited rights only. They are not entitled to representation at meetings and conferences of the IPU and the CPA. They are also not entitled to the travel concessions provided to members by certain branches of the CPA.

The Speaker of the Lok Sabha is the *ex officio* President of the IPG. The Deputy Speaker of the Lok Sabha and the Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha are the *ex officio* vice-presidents of the IPG. The Secretary-General of the Lok Sabha acts as the *ex officio* Secretary-General of the IPG.

OBJECTIVES OF THE IPG

The aims and objects of the IPG are mentioned below:

1. To promote personal contact between members of the Parliament of India.
2. To study questions of public importance that are likely to come up before the Parliament; arrange seminars, discussions and orientation courses; and bring out publications for the dissemination of information to the members of the IPG.
3. To arrange lectures on political, defence, economic, social and educational problems by the members of the Parliament and distinguished persons.